

The Doorway

Thumbnail Image

A hand manipulating the joystick of a power wheelchair steering console takes up the right side of the image against the background of a cement sidewalk and a black doormat. The title, "The Doorway" is overlaid in red and blue.

Title screen

We open on a black screen with the title, "The Doorway" in white text in the center, and smaller text at the bottom reading, "A film by Lydia McDermott and Sueli Gwiazdowski."

Audio-visual Description

The video opens with a lot of background noises of chatter and traffic as well as clattering of metal. The camera point of view is from a power wheelchair. The title of the film, "The Doorway," flashes in the center of the screen above the hand of the wheelchair user steering the wheelchair with a joystick controller. We can hear the motor of the wheelchair, but it is quiet. We, through the camera's view, are approaching an exterior door of an academic building. As the wheelchair user reaches for the handle of the door, new text comes across the bottom of the screen in typewriter fashion: "Whitman College **is committed** to ensuring accessibility for all members of our community." The text is primarily white, but "is committed" is red. The hand opens the door with much effort as this text is "typing" across the screen. The wheelchair user holds open the door while driving the chair through the doorway and into the building. The camera turns back to face the closing glass door. The names "Lydia McDermott and Sueli Gwiazdowski" appear in black font at the bottom of the screen, as the door closes, showing the reflection of Sueli's legs in her wheelchair.

Drumbeat music rises in volume and the ambient background noise ends. The camera switches to a side view of Sueli driving her chair toward the right of the screen in front of the stairs to the building we just "entered." She is using a manual wheelchair in this scene. As she disappears from the right side of the screen, text again "types" across the bottom of the screen: "We **aim to provide** an accessible experience where all individuals can access programs, opportunities, and activities." The text is white except for the verbal, "aim to provide," which is red. By the time the full typewritten text has arrived on screen, Sueli has appeared from screen

right on the second level patio of the building at the top of the steps, having accessed the ramp that took her out of view for a few seconds. She is making her way to the same door. A fellow student exits, but does not offer to hold the door. As Sueli begins the process of opening the door, new text is typed across the bottom of the screen: "Additionally Whitman College **is committed to promoting access and awareness** as a resource to all community members." Only "is committed to promoting access and awareness" is in red font. Sueli gets the door open, while it actively shuts against her wheelchair.

As the door closes, the drumbeats reach a crescendo. New text is typed across the bottom of the screen: "We **are committed to ensuring** that all persons in our community and visitors to our campus **feel welcome and included** . . ." The viewpoint changes again to zoom in closer on the door as Sueli opens it again. She makes her way through in the manual chair as the door bumps the side and back of her chair trying to close. The text continues at the bottom of the screen: "and that appropriate accessibility accommodations **have been provided** for those who **require this service**." The font is red for "have been provided" and "require this service." The door closes.

The camera view is now a side view of the windows of the building on the wall adjacent to the door. We see the door in "profile." Sueli's reflection in the windows appears first entering from screen right in her power chair as she again opens this door. In this case, the power chair is more moveable and Sueli can pivot the chair while opening the door before turning to enter through the door more quickly than she was able to in the manual chair. Sueli gets through the door. During this scene, the music has faded and is replaced by Sueli's voice-over.

Sueli's Voiceover

I started thinking about pieces of facilities and physical structures that I think stick out to me, and doorways were one of those things. And I feel like the doorway really captures the beginning of moving into a space, of course, the beginning of being separated from normative individuals in an educational setting. Had disabled people been part of the policy conversations that exist within the decision making rooms at colleges and universities, the landscape for disabled students would look very, very different and much more accessible. From my position as a student, I think these policy spaces are ineffectual. They don't make enduring change, at

least to the extent that I'm not experiencing the level of access that I believe I deserve as a student. [Music then resumes].

Visual Description

Midway through the above voiceover, the camera changes view again, looking down the sidewalk where we can see the ramp to the building, which we presumed Sueli had used when disappearing from the screen earlier, to the left side of the screen, while a street of parked cars is to the right. Sueli approaches from across the street in her power chair and comes toward the camera, face on. Sueli ascends the ramp and the camera adjusts to keep her in the center of the screen. New white text in quotation marks is typed across the top of the screen. This text is NOT captioning of what the Sueli is narrating in audio, but a quotation from a text: "If rhetoric is the circulation of discourse through the body, . . ." Sueli turns the corner of the switchback style ramp and is facing away from us. She turns the last corner and comes toward and then past us to the left. The screen changes and the camera is looking at the blank sidewalk. We can just see the top of the LCD panel attached to the joystick steering of the power chair in the bottom right corner.

We are now repeating the same journey we just viewed, but from the first-person wheelchair user view, in handheld camera footage. The quote continues across the top of the screen: ". . . then spaces and institutions cannot be disconnected from the bodies within them, . . ." At the top of the ramp and the last left turn, the rest of the quote is typed on screen: ". . . the bodies they selectively exclude, and the bodies that actively intervene to reshape them" (Dolmage 106). We quickly pass some sidewalk chalk, one word of which that stands out is "WELCOME" in all caps, making our way to the doorway again to open it again. Audio interview begins again as the door opens.

Spoken Audio Resumes, Sueli's Voiceover

Professor McDermott and my friend, Ilse Spiropoulis, who is a staff member here at Whitman and also a wheelchair user, [were] doing some research for a conference, a symposium that we presented at the Power and Privilege Symposium. And I came across a letter to the editor from 1990 written by an anonymous student who was a woman and a wheelchair user who detailed her experience moving through the college down to the nitty-gritty of what different elevators were like and which pathways were accessible and which ones were not and activities and

experiences that the student was barred from because of inaccessibility and ableism. And not only was that letter, of course, very powerful, the student signed the letter off, calling herself, signed "the campus afterthought", which was both heartbreaking and also felt very... I resonated with it. What really stuck out to me was that the student was describing very specific pieces of structural inequity and inaccessibility that I and other students with disabilities at Whitman College experience today. And this letter was written in 1990, in November, which means it was written the same year that the ADA was signed into law.

Visual Description of Video:

We come through the door into the building, where we have a quick view of the interior, including brick walls, bulletin boards, many windows, stairs, and a large "life size" chess board on the ground. We turn to face the reflection in the door. The video cross fades to show a close up still of a newspaper. The top reads "Letters to the Editor." In bolded font at the top of the left hand column is the heading, "Whitman College discriminates against the disabled students." This is the letter that Sueli references in the audio. The entire letter is not visible, but much of it is. It begins, for instance, "Does anyone realize how discriminatory this narrow-minded little school is?" White text in quotation marks is "typed" across the top of the screen: an excerpt from the letter. "Every day I am forced to use back entrances to buildings, rickety makeshift ramps, and dirty elevators . . ." This is as the audio voice over says, "details her experience moving through the college." As the text is being "typed," the video cross fades to a still black and white photograph of two college aged people. The man on the left stands, hands in pockets, looking off to the left, a single backpack strap over his right shoulder. He wears dark sunglasses and a vertically striped shirt. Next to him is a young woman running her hand through her light bob. She is also wearing dark sunglasses and looking in the opposite direction. She has a horizontally striped shirt on. She is in a power wheelchair. (This is a photograph from the yearbook of 1990-91. It is the only photograph of a wheelchair user). The camera pans down the photograph.

The video cross fades to a very old sepia-toned photograph of a stone and brick college building with a clock tower and steep steps to an arched doorway. This cross fades to another old photograph of the same building from the other side, and looking down the street where we see black model-T cars on the road. It cross fades again to show the same building from a view across the street. There are patriotic banners hung from windows and the clock tower and a

large crowd of people is gathered on the front lawn facing the street in anticipation of a visit by President Theodore Roosevelt, May 25, 1903. As these photos appear, a new excerpt of the letter is "typed" across the top of the screen: "I realize this is an old school and maybe when it was built, it never occurred to anyone that disabled people could even go to college . . ." As Sueli describes the end of the letter, the camera cross fades to an illustration of the same college building. New typewritten text appears across the top of the screen: the conclusion of the letter. "So much for accommodating my handicap. With ruffled feathers, The campus After-thought." We cross fade back to the same first-person point of view video in the power wheel chair, with the joystick steering control in the bottom left corner.

Description with Audio Transcript

The screen transitions to a video interview with Sueli sitting in a teal chair in front of a corner between a teal wall with a pride flag hanging behind them, and a yellow wall with floor to ceiling window right next to Sueli. Sueli is a white-presenting Latina with long, blond wavy hair, and pink hexagonal glasses. She wears a black tank top and a pearl necklace. There are homey knick knacks on the desk behind them, as well as a coffee maker. Sueli is nearly centered on screen, a bit to the right. She delivers the following story.

Sueli:

So last academic year, a group of Whitman College students found my power wheelchair in the basement of the all-women's dormitory on campus, and took my power wheelchair for an unauthorized joyride. They took my power wheelchair and rode it without permission and took a video of themselves sitting in my chair, (multiple people in my chair at one point), and crashed it into a wall and damaged my chair and damaged college property, of course, but more importantly, my chair. I came to find out about this because there were a number of student witnesses who saw this all unfold and heard it all unfold. I came to find my power wheelchair at that point, which was one of my primary sources of movement throughout this campus, damaged where I had left it. I remember finding out and just instantly feeling the level of violation that I don't think I can even articulate. I don't even know how to put it into words, how violated and how belittled and how disrespected And, yeah, fundamentally violated, I felt.

The camera transitions away from Sueli, though the interview continues.

Audio Transcription (with visual description embedded in italics)

(We see the yearbook photograph from 1990 again.) We do have to think about that. We do have to think about where we belong, where we can put our bodies and our stuff and our mobility aids, where we can move because in spaces of education, *(screen transitions to first person point of view power chair scene opening door again. Background noises are included this time. We hear the banging of the door against the chair and chatter in the distance. This time, overlaid across the video is a line drawing schematic of the adequate proportions of an ADA accessible doorway from an overhead view, with a person in a wheelchair passing through an automatically opened door. It is labelled. Fig. 7. (United Nations Enable). Other than the overlay, the video is the same.)* we literally do not belong. We are not able to open the doors. We are not able to participate in class equitably. We are separated from our peers. We are completely and utterly left behind and afterthoughts within our student bodies.

(The camera transitions to the same video view of Sueli coming up the street to use the ramp. This time there is ambient background noise. Text again arrives across the top of the screen in quotation marks: "When accommodations that students with disabilities have access to, over and over again, are intended ...") And we as disabled people within the educational setting, where we are already barred from access, *(Quotation continues across the top of the screen: ". . . to simply temporarily even the playing field for them in a single class or activity, it is clear that these . . ." Sueli turns the last corner of the switchback ramp.)* are also turned into learning moments. We exist as tools for our normative peers to learn from. And I think that my experiences *(screen transitions to the view of Sueli approaching the door to open it)* having my wheelchair taken from me and used against my will encapsulate that process— *(typed text continues across the top of the screen as Sueli opens the door: ". . . retrofits are not designed for people to live and thrive with a disability . . ." Screen transitions to the close up of the Letter to the Editor from earlier. On top of the letter to the editor, the end of the quotation is typed across the top of the screen: ". . . but rather to temporarily **make the disability go away**" (Dolmage Academic Ableism 70).)* of me existing here as a student on a full-needs-met scholarship, as the first in my family to attend college and seek a higher education degree as a student with a disability.

I exist here as a learning moment for the normative and privileged students who attend this college.

(No audio as we pan the letter)

Sueli voices again:

I exist here as a learning moment for the normative and privileged students who attend this college.

End Credits Description

The screen transitions to black with the accessible door blueprint overlay atop. Drumming music resumes. Credits run along the bottom of the screen: "The Doorway," a film by Lydia McDermott and Sueli Gwiazdowski, featuring camera work by Echo Ensor-McDermott. ** This is not a critique of a particular institution, but of how institutions talk about accessibility verbally, nonverbally, and through their physical and bureaucratic structures."